

DRYWALL PRO



Job Safety & OSHA Compliance Guide

Essential safety protocols, PPE requirements, dust control strategies, and OSHA regulations every drywall professional must know.

Drywall Pro — Professional Reference Series

1 Required PPE (Personal Protective Equipment)

Proper PPE is your first line of defense on every drywall job. OSHA requires employers to provide appropriate protective equipment at no cost to workers. Use this checklist before every shift.

 **OSHA Standard 1926.95:** Employers must assess the workplace for hazards and provide the appropriate PPE. Workers must wear it whenever hazards are present.

- ☐ **Dust Mask / Respirator**
N95 minimum for sanding operations. P100 for heavy dust or cement board cutting. Replace filters per manufacturer schedule. Fit-test annually.
- ☐ **Safety Glasses**
ANSI Z87.1 rated required. Side shields recommended. Use sealed goggles for overhead sanding work.
- ☐ **Work Gloves**
Leather or cut-resistant for carrying/handling sheets. Nitrile or latex disposable gloves for mudding and taping. Replace when torn.
- ☐ **Knee Pads**
Gel or foam construction-grade pads. Essential for baseboard work, bottom-row screwing, and floor-level mudding. Prevents long-term knee injury.
- ☐ **Hard Hat**
Required on all construction sites with overhead hazards. Type I minimum; Type II for lateral impact protection.
- ☐ **Steel-Toe Boots**
Recommended for carrying 4×8 or 4×12 panels. ASTM F2413 rated. Non-slip soles essential for dusty surfaces.
- ☐ **Hearing Protection**
Required when using power tools (routers, screw guns, saws). NRR 25+ earplugs or earmuffs when noise exceeds 85 dB.

 **Pro Tip:** Keep a spare set of disposable N95 masks and safety glasses in your truck at all times. A \$2 mask can prevent thousands in medical bills.

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Dust Control

Drywall dust is the most common health hazard on the job. Prolonged exposure causes respiratory issues, eye irritation, and skin problems. Effective dust control protects you, your crew, and the homeowner's property.

METHOD	HOW IT WORKS	EFFECTIVENESS
Wet Sanding	Use a damp sponge or wet sandpaper. Captures dust particles before they become airborne.	Reduces airborne dust 80%+
Vacuum Sanding	HEPA-equipped pole sanders with integrated vacuum attachment. Captures dust at the source.	Reduces airborne dust 90%+
Plastic Sheeting	Seal off work area with 4-mil or 6-mil poly sheeting. Use painter's tape on all edges. Create a containment zone.	Effective containment
HVAC Protection	Cover all vents, returns, and air handlers with plastic and tape before sanding. Prevent dust circulating through the system.	Prevents system damage
Air Scrubber	Portable HEPA air filtration unit. Rental ~\$50-100/day. Essential for occupied renovation work.	Hospital-grade filtration

**Silica Dust Warning:** Cutting cement board or fiber-cement products releases crystalline silica dust. OSHA PEL is 50 µg/m³ over an 8-hour TWA. Always use P100 respirator and wet-cutting methods for these materials. Silica exposure can cause silicosis, an irreversible lung disease.

OSHA Permissible Exposure Limits

Gypsum Dust (Total)

- PEL: 15 mg/m³ (total dust)
- PEL: 5 mg/m³ (respirable fraction)
- Standard joint compound & drywall dust

Crystalline Silica

- PEL: 50 µg/m³ (8-hr TWA)
- Action Level: 25 µg/m³
- Cement board, fiber-cement, some textures

**Best Practice:** Combine methods for maximum protection. Use vacuum sanding inside a contained area with an air scrubber running. This multi-layer approach achieves near-zero airborne dust levels.

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Scaffolding & Ladder Safety

Falls are the leading cause of death in construction. Drywall installers work at height daily. Following these rules is not optional — it saves lives.

 **OSHA 1926.501:** Fall protection is required for all workers at heights of 6 feet or more above a lower level. This includes guardrails, safety nets, or personal fall arrest systems.

Ladder Safety Rules

Step Ladders

- Always fully open and locked
- Never stand on top two rungs
- Do not use as a straight ladder
- Place on firm, level surface
- Face ladder when climbing

Extension Ladders

- **4-to-1 Rule:** Base 1 ft out for every 4 ft up
- Extend 3 ft above landing point
- Three-point contact always
- Secure top and bottom
- Never carry heavy loads on ladders

Scaffolding Requirements

TYPE	REQUIREMENTS	KEY RULES
Baker Scaffolding	Interior work, adjustable height. Ideal for hanging and finishing ceilings.	Lock casters before climbing. Fully planked platform. Max height per manufacturer specs.
Frame Scaffolding	Exterior and large interior work. Must be erected by competent person.	Level ground with base plates. Guardrails above 10 ft. Cross-bracing on all sections.
Drywall Stilts	For taping and finishing. Must have proper training before use.	Only on solid, flat floors. Not on scaffolds or ladders. Max height per state regulation.

 **Stilts Training:** Many states require formal training before workers can use drywall stilts. Check your state and local regulations. Never use stilts on wet, uneven, or cluttered surfaces. Remove stilts to use ladders or scaffolding.

 **Three-Point Contact:** Always maintain two hands and one foot, or two feet and one hand on the ladder. Never lean beyond arm's reach — move the ladder instead.

4 Electrical Awareness on Job Sites

Drywall installers frequently work around live wiring. Cutting or screwing into a live circuit is one of the most dangerous mistakes on the job. Know before you cut.

 **Electrocution is the #4 cause of construction fatalities.** Never assume a circuit is dead. Always test before cutting into walls or ceilings.

Before You Cut or Screw

- ☐ **Identify all circuits in the work area**
Review the electrical panel. Map which breakers control which areas. Mark live circuits clearly.
- ☐ **Use a non-contact voltage tester (NCVT)**
Scan every stud bay before cutting. Test around outlet boxes, switch boxes, and ceiling fixtures. Cost: \$15-25. Keep one in your pouch at all times.
- ☐ **Request de-energization when possible**
Ask the electrician or GC to shut off circuits in your work zone. Verify with your own tester.
- ☐ **Use GFCI protection for all power tools**
OSHA requires GFCI protection on construction sites. Use GFCI-equipped cords or portable GFCI adapters.
- ☐ **Manage cords to prevent tripping**
Route cords along walls, not across walkways. Use cord covers when crossing paths. Inspect cords for damage daily.

Lockout / Tagout Awareness

When circuits must be de-energized for your safety, the electrician applies a lock and tag to the breaker. **Never** remove someone else's lock. Only the person who placed the lock may remove it.

 **If You Hit a Wire:** (1) Stop immediately. Do not pull the tool out. (2) Turn off the breaker if safe to do so. (3) If someone is being shocked, do NOT touch them — use a non-conductive object to separate them from the source. (4) Call 911 for any electric shock, even if the person feels fine. Internal injuries can be delayed.

Power Tool Safety

Required Practices

- Inspect tools and cords before each use
- Use double-insulated tools when available
- Never carry tools by the cord
- Disconnect when changing bits or blades

Common Hazards

- Damaged cord insulation
- Missing ground prongs (never remove)
- Wet conditions without GFCI
- Overloaded circuits / daisy-chained strips

5 OSHA Requirements for Drywall Workers

OSHA (Occupational Safety and Health Administration) sets and enforces safety standards for all construction workers. Knowing your rights and your employer's obligations keeps you safe and legal.

Hazard Communication (HazCom)

i Right to Know: You have the legal right to know about every chemical hazard on your job site. Your employer must provide Safety Data Sheets (SDS) for all products, including joint compound, primers, adhesives, and texture materials.

Common OSHA Citations in Drywall Work

VIOLATION	OSHA STANDARD	TYPICAL FINE
Fall protection not provided	1926.501	\$5,000 – \$15,625
Scaffold not constructed properly	1926.451	\$5,000 – \$15,625
Ladder violations	1926.1053	\$5,000 – \$15,625
No respiratory protection program	1910.134	\$5,000 – \$15,625
Missing HazCom/SDS	1910.1200	\$5,000 – \$15,625
No electrical GFCI protection	1926.405	\$5,000 – \$15,625

Weekly Toolbox Talk Topics

Safety Topics

- PPE inspection and proper use
- Ladder and scaffold safety
- Dust control and respiratory protection
- Electrical hazard awareness
- Heat illness prevention

Compliance Topics

- SDS location and how to read them
- Reporting injuries and near-misses
- Emergency evacuation procedures
- New worker orientation checklist
- Housekeeping and material storage

Your Rights as a Worker

✓ You have the right to: (1) A safe workplace free from recognized hazards. (2) Receive training in a language you understand. (3) Refuse dangerous work if you believe there is imminent danger. (4) File a confidential complaint with OSHA without retaliation. (5) Review your employer's injury and illness records.

⚠ Recordkeeping: Employers with 11+ employees must keep OSHA 300 logs of all work-related injuries and illnesses. You have the right to review these records for your workplace.

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Emergency Procedures

Knowing how to respond to common drywall injuries can prevent minor incidents from becoming serious. Every crew should have a plan before work begins.

Job Site First Aid Kit Essentials

Basic Supplies

- Adhesive bandages (various sizes)
- Sterile gauze pads and rolls
- Medical tape
- Antiseptic wipes
- Disposable gloves (nitrile)
- Scissors and tweezers

Drywall-Specific Additions

- Eye wash solution (dust exposure)
- Butterfly closures (deep paper cuts)
- Cold packs (sprains/impacts)
- Burn cream (power tool friction)
- Saline solution (eye flush)
- Emergency blanket

Common Injury Response

INJURY	IMMEDIATE ACTION	SEEK MEDICAL CARE IF
Cuts from sheet edges	Apply direct pressure with clean gauze. Clean wound. Apply butterfly closure or bandage. Drywall edges cause deep, clean cuts.	Bleeding does not stop in 10 min. Cut is deep or on the hand/wrist.
Dust in eyes	Do NOT rub. Flush with clean water or eye wash for 15 minutes. Blink frequently.	Vision is blurred after flushing. Pain persists. Embedded particle.
Fall injury	Do not move the person if spinal injury is suspected. Stabilize. Keep warm and calm.	Any fall from 6+ ft. Loss of consciousness. Neck/back pain.
Strain / sprain	R.I.C.E.: Rest, Ice, Compression, Elevation. Remove from work activity.	Unable to bear weight. Significant swelling. Heard a pop.

Call 911 Immediately For: Any fall from height with injury. Loss of consciousness. Electric shock (even brief). Uncontrolled bleeding. Suspected broken bones. Chest pain or difficulty breathing. Allergic reaction (some joint compounds contain allergens).

Incident Documentation

Every injury and near-miss must be documented, no matter how minor. This protects you and helps prevent future incidents.

- ☐ Record the date, time, and location of the incident
- ☐ Describe exactly what happened and who was involved

- ☐ Document the injury type and first aid given
- ☐ Take photos of the scene and any hazards
- ☐ Report to supervisor immediately
- ☐ File workers' comp paperwork within 24 hours if applicable

i Near-Miss Reporting: A near-miss today is tomorrow's injury. Report every close call — it is not a sign of weakness, it is how professional crews prevent real injuries.

Next Step

You now have the essential safety knowledge every professional drywall installer needs. Put these practices into action on your very next job.

Review the PPE checklist before each shift. Run a 5-minute toolbox talk with your crew every morning. Make safety a habit, not an afterthought.

Apply What You've Learned — Start Tomorrow

Safety is a skill that improves with practice. The most successful drywall professionals are the ones who go home healthy every single day.

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